Curiosity is the Strategic Advantage in an Age of Unprecedented Change.



In a world defined by volatility, uncertainty, complexity, and ambiguity (VUCA), the ability to explore, question, and learn is no longer a luxury—it is the essential engine for value creation and survival.

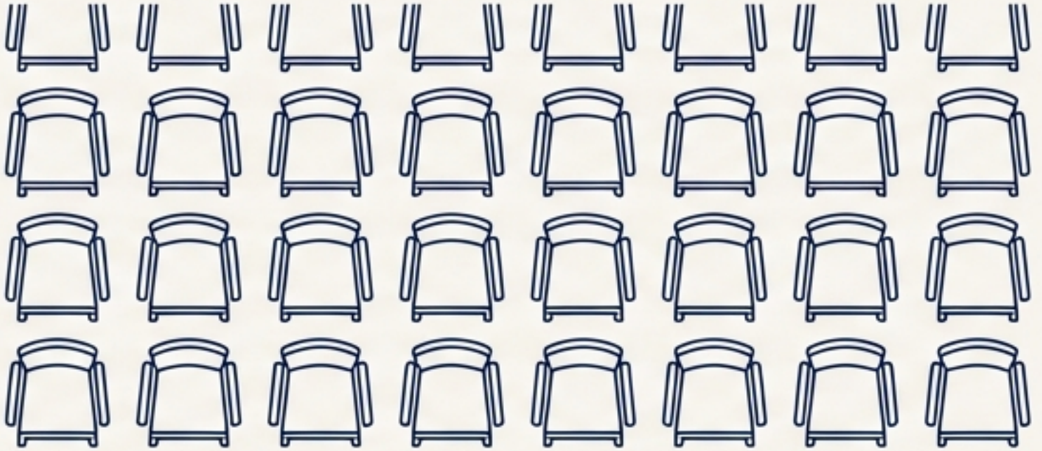
The pace of change has never been this fast, yet it will never be this slow again.

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We Are Born Curious, But Taught to Comply



Research indicates we are at our most curious around **age four**. This innate drive is often dampened by well-meaning parents (“Don’t touch that"), educational frameworks prioritizing predictability, and workplace cultures that sacrifice experimentation for efficiency.



The Corporate Dilemma: Exploit vs. Explore

Author Daniel Goleman explains the two primary strategies are "exploit" and "explore".

Exploit: *"Refine a topic that I could spin around and add something to... a company that has a product that makes money that they tweak every year so that it keeps bringing in the cash." (The Status Quo)*

Explore: *"To be curious, to look around and to find something new... Genius is hitting the target others do not see." (The Path of Innovation)*

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Curiosity is the Brain’s Reward System for Learning

From Wonder to Action

Curiosity isn't passive; it's an active process of reconciling new information with what we already know. It is the engine that converts wonder into engagement with the world.

“To wonder is just to keep it in your head. To be curious is fundamentally to engage in the world.”



Dopamine Release

When we're curious, the brain's reward and pleasure centers are activated, releasing dopamine. This not only feels good but permits new connections between neurons, making learning addictive and more effective.

Enhanced Memory

A University of California study found that invoking curiosity at the point of learning aids in the retention of information and creates stronger memories. The hippocampus is sparked, which rewards us for being curious.

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The Measurable ROI of a Curious Mindset



Enhanced Innovation

Curious individuals are more likely to generate novel solutions. INSEAD research directly links curiosity to higher innovation output.



Better Decision-Making

Curiosity drives a more thorough exploration of alternatives and their implications, leading to more robust decisions.



Reduced Team Conflict

A curious approach encourages understanding others' perspectives ("I wonder why they see it that way?") rather than defending a single viewpoint.



Stronger Communication & Collaboration

Curious people listen better, fostering trust and cooperation across teams and functions.

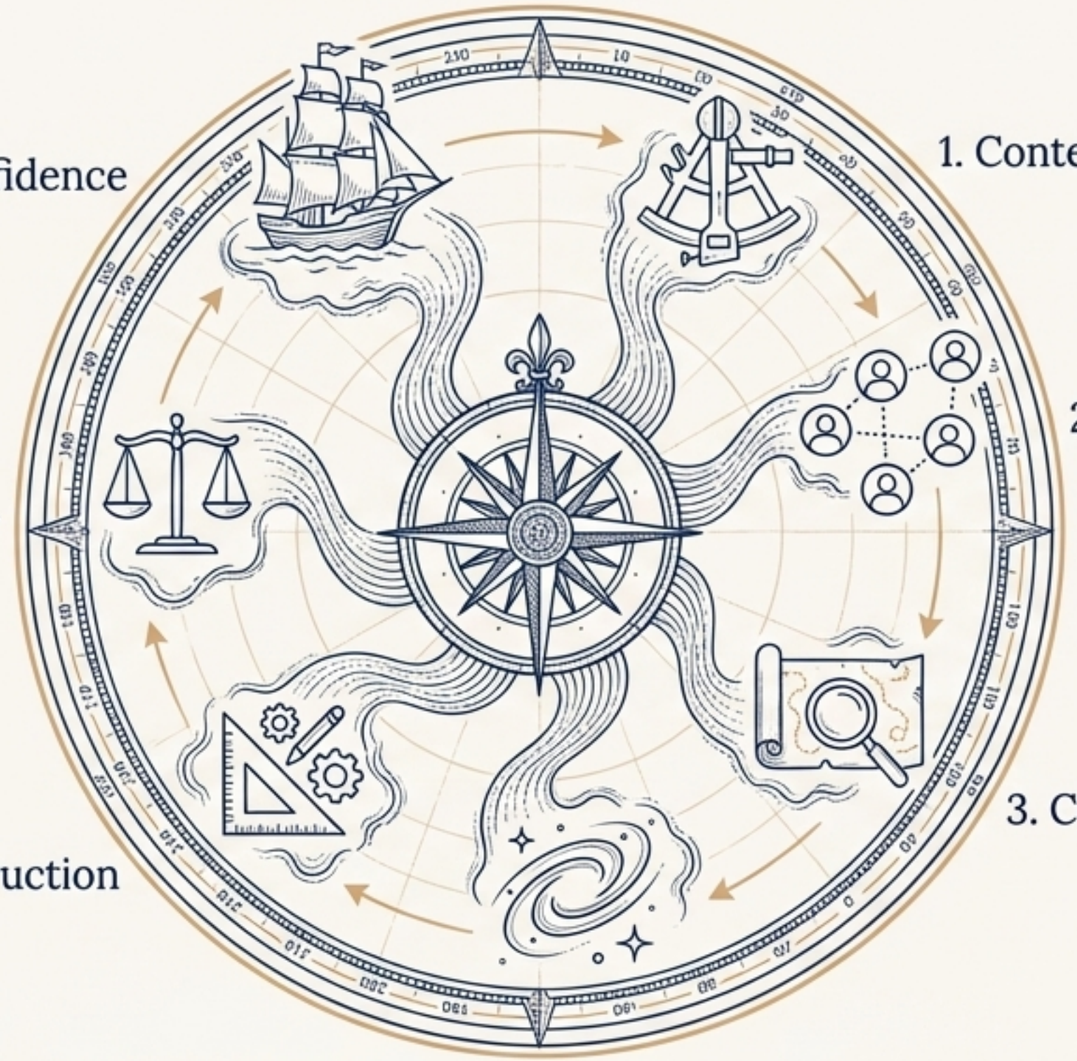


Increased Adaptability

In a rapidly changing world, the ability and willingness to learn—fueled by curiosity—is the ultimate competitive skill.

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Sailing the 7 Cs: A Practical Framework for Activating Curiosity



If you ask people *how* to be more curious, most have no idea. The 7 Cs provide a map to guide yourself—and your organization—to become more effective at exploration and discovery.

1. **Context**
2. **Community**
3. **Curation**
4. **Creativity**
5. **Construction**
6. **Criticality**
7. **Confidence**

Framework credit: Sailing the 7 Cs is from The Curious Advantage (2020) by Paul Ashcroft, Simon Brown & Garrick Jones.

The 7 Cs, Part 1: Setting Your Course



1. Context

Zooming out to see the bigger picture. Without context, curiosity can be misdirected.

Analogy: "Imagine entering a smart room. If you don't know about the voice-activated lights (the context), your exploration will focus on finding a light switch you'll never find."



2. Community

Leveraging interactions to synthesize ideas. Curiosity is not a solo activity.

Insight: People in your community play different roles: mentors, critics, sponsors, deep-dive experts, and peers who hold you accountable.



3. Curation

Structured selection in an age of information overload. Not every idea is worth exploring.

Insight: "With endless information, curation of the most reputable and relevant content takes on a critical role. AI and new technologies can help customize content to individual needs."

Framework credit: Sailing the 7 Cs is from The Curious Advantage (2020) by Paul Ashcroft, Simon Brown & Garrick Jones.

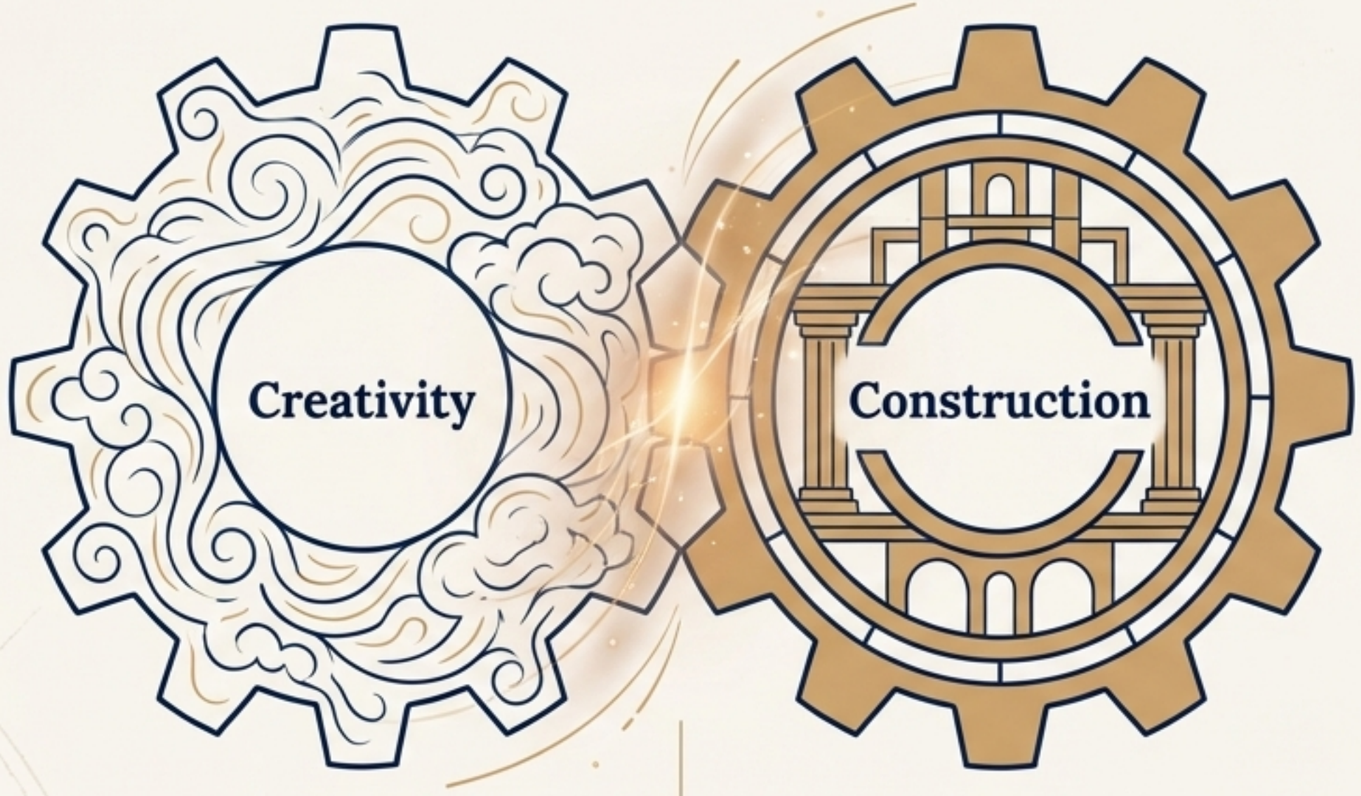
The 7 Cs, Part 2: Igniting the Curiosity Engine



4. Creativity

Allowing the mind to explore different roads with no specific goal.

A study found that participants who spent more unstructured time exploring reading material before a task came up with more innovative solutions. "People need idle time during which they aren't focusing on a specific task."





5. Construction

Moving from exploring and learning to impactful implementation through tangible action.

"Discuss ideas with others. Test and prototype through models and presentations. Find platforms or simulations to accelerate your process. Always document your attempts."

The combination of Creativity and Construction is the **Curiosity Engine**: the core loop of asking "what if" and then trying it out.

Framework credit: Sailing the 7 Cs is from The Curious Advantage (2020) by Paul Ashcroft, Simon Brown & Garrick Jones.

The 7 Cs, Part 3: Refining the Journey and Building Momentum



6. Criticality

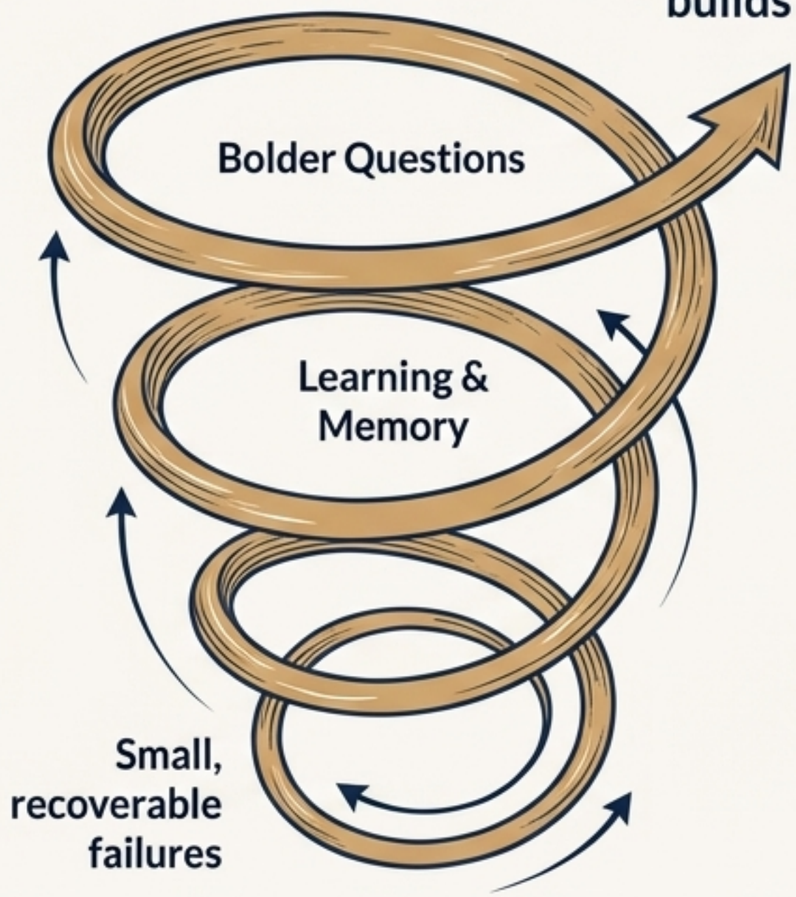
Applying skepticism (not cynicism) to prevent falling for bias, fake news, and lies.

Mantra

- ☐ Question everything.
- ☐ Become aware of your conscious and unconscious biases.
- ☐ Probe whether your ideas will work for people who aren't like you.

7. Confidence

Confidence enables curiosity, and the process of curiosity builds confidence.



Failure teaches you how to recover, so you lose fear. Learning through small, recoverable failures **failures** to **builds memory and confidence**, which in turn allows you to ask bolder questions and tackle bigger challenges. Confidence is both the last C and the first.

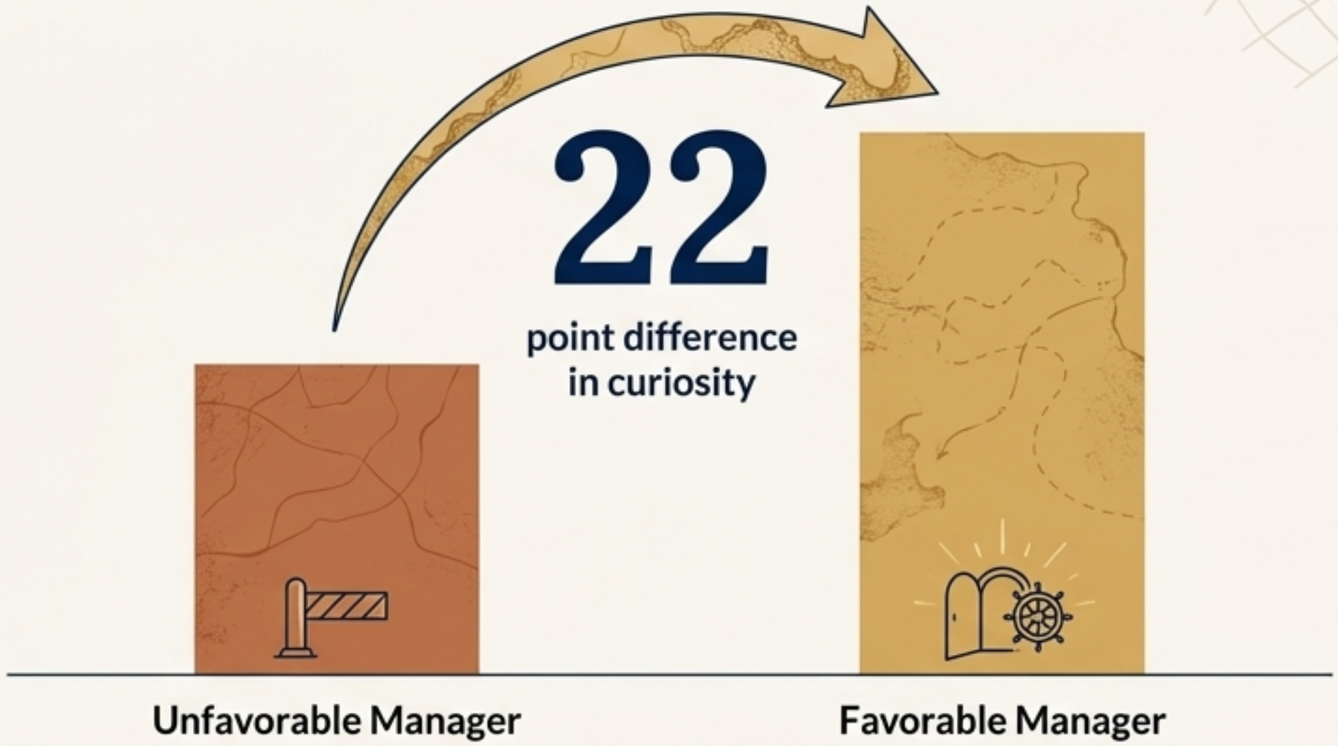
Framework credit: Sailing the 7 Cs is from The Curious Advantage (2020) by Paul Ashcroft, Simon Brown & Garrick Jones.

A Leader's Behavior Can Make or Break a Culture of Curiosity

The Manager Effect

The role of the manager is the single biggest influence on a team's curiosity. It's about creating psychological safety where people feel they can experiment, fail, fail, and speak up.

Finding from internal Novartis research.



"If I have a favorable manager, I feel I can be curious. As soon as I have an unfavorable manager, it just stops me from asking questions, sharing ideas, and trying new things."

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Inside Novartis: Architecting a Global Culture of Curiosity

Cultural Aspiration: “Inspired, Curious, and Unbossed.”

Key Initiatives & Programs



The 100-Hour Aspiration: A clear signal for employees to spend 5% of their time (100 hours/year) on their own learning, addressing the “I don't have time" barrier.



Global Learning Platform: Offers curated content from Coursera, LinkedIn Learning, and top universities.



Curiosity Month: A full month of events, global webinars, and activities to engage people around learning.



Internal TEDx Events: Employees volunteer and are trained to share ideas, broadcast to the whole company.

Measuring Progress



Based on quarterly engagement survey of over 70,000 employees.

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Microsoft’s Renaissance: From ‘Know-it-all’ to ‘Learn-it-all’.

Before: The ‘Know-it-all’ Era



By 2014, Microsoft was seen by many as a relic. The culture was described as arrogant, insular, and grasping for answers but unable to see the enemy within.

After: The ‘Learn-it-all’ Renaissance



When Satya Nadella became CEO, he revitalized the company by instilling a growth mindset with a deep desire to learn.

The culture moved from a ‘know-it-all" philosophy to a ‘learn-it-all’ philosophy.

This shift encouraged employees to stay inquisitive and continuously seek knowledge. Today, Microsoft has regained its place among the world's most innovative and valuable firms, demonstrating how a culture of curiosity can lead to remarkable rejuvenation.

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Proof Points: Curiosity-Driven Success Across Industries



Finance (Bankinter)

Spain's most innovative bank runs a think tank and streams the content directly to every employee's desktop, "flushing the system" with new ideas and context.

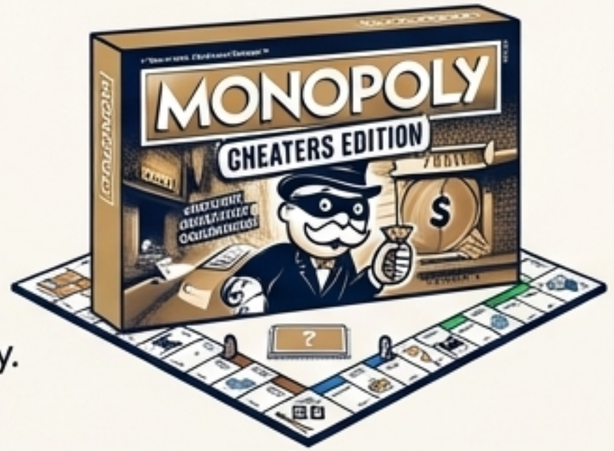


Toys (Lego)

After nearly failing, Lego shifted from suing people who hacked their tools to embracing them as "super users," co-creating products with children as young as three.

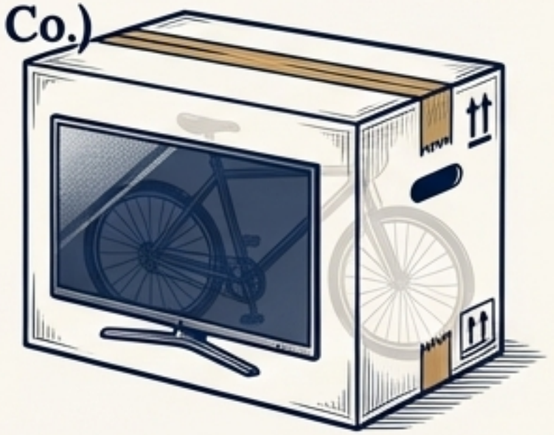
Gaming (Monopoly)

After research revealed that 50% of players cheat, their curiosity led them to launch the "Cheaters Edition," which became the second-best launch in the product's history.



Logistics (Electric Bike Co.)

Problem: bikes were breaking during shipping.
Curious solution: They printed a picture of a flat-screen TV on the box. Handlers became more careful. Breakage stopped.



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Overcoming the Four Factors That Inhibit Curiosity

The F.A.T.E. Framework identifies the four key factors that stop curiosity.

Fear



Fear of failure, of asking "stupid" questions, of challenging authority.

Assumptions



The belief that we already know the answer; "this is how we've always done it."

Technology



Over-reliance on technology for answers can atrophy our own exploratory muscles.

Environment

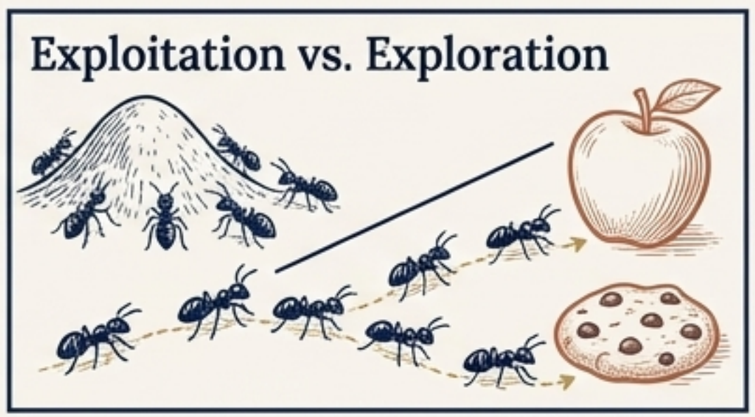


A culture that lacks psychological safety, punishes failure, or provides no time for exploration.

Objection: "I don't want them going down rabbit holes."







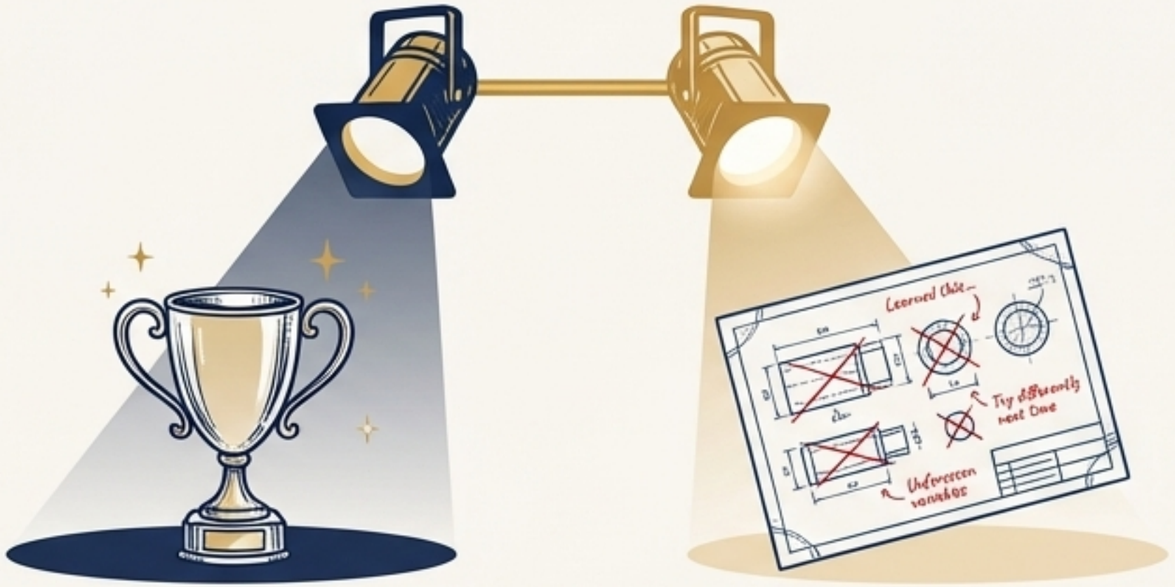
The "Ant Hill and the Big Mac" Analogy: A curious organization is always exploring for new food sources,

Framework credit: F.A.T.E. is from Cracking the Curiosity Code (2019) by Dr Diane Hamilton.

Rewarding the Attempt, Not Just the Outcome

The Problem

Many leaders say they encourage curiosity, but their employees don't feel it. Francesca Gino's HBR research shows the disconnect often lies in what gets rewarded.



SUCCESS

INSTRUCTIVE FAILURE

A New Approach

Companies like IBM actively reward people who try and fail. At project-end reviews, they celebrate successes AND applaud the things that were tried but didn't work out.



Real-World Example: Reframing Failure

Ben & Jerry's “Flavor Graveyard” is a celebration of what no longer works. When a flavor is discontinued, they give it a “gravestone” on their website. It reframes failure as a natural and celebrated part of the innovation lifecycle.

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In the Future of Work, Curiosity is the Ultimate Human Advantage.

The Enduring Value of "Power Skills"

The shelf life of technical skills is shrinking rapidly. Soft skills—or "power skills"—like creativity, collaboration, and adaptability have far longer relevance. Curiosity is the skill that fuels all of them.



The Future Workforce

"Repetitive tasks will be done for us by bots and the human focus will be on the non-repetitive elements, the unusual, the creative, the personal, the discovery and the innovative."

Curiosity is not just a method for improving performance today. It is the lifeline that allows individuals and **organizations to remain relevant, resilient**, and ready to **navigate a future** that is still being written.

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